

SOC 300: Foundations of Social Inquiry

Summer 2025

Mondays and Wednesday
2:30 - 4:30 p.m.

<https://washington.zoom.us/j/91812345678>

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Office Hours:
Mondays 4:30 to 5:30
Or by Appointment

COURSE DESCRIPTION

As suggested by the name, this course serves the purpose of building a foundation of knowledge and skills for how to both understand and contribute to social science research. Rather than focus on a specific sub-topic of the social world as many courses within our department do, this course will zoom out to focus on the methods that researchers in the social sciences use to produce the knowledge that you've learned in those topic-specific courses. Even if you do not plan to go on to graduate school and become a social scientist, the knowledge and skill you gain in this course will make you a more informed consumer of scientific research that is covered in popular media. Additionally, understanding the logic of inquiry that social scientists use you will gain an appreciation for what separates sociology and other social sciences from less rigorous ways of understanding the social world such as anecdotes from personal experience, cherry-picked relationships between variables, opinion pieces, and ideological motivated research practices or presentation of results.

COMMUNICATION

The best way to get in touch with me with specific questions is via email (tnobles@uw.edu). However, I strongly encourage you to come to my office hours if you have larger questions or concerns about the material or the course. If you're unable to make that time, please reach out to me over email and we can arrange another time. You can expect to hear back from me within 48 hours during the week and if you email me on a Friday then you can expect a response by the end of day the following Monday.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this course students will be able to:

- explain what separates social science from other ways of understanding the social world
- summarize the main findings and identify core components of original sociological research articles
- differentiate between the various study designs within sociological research
- identify an appropriate research design given a question of interest
- assess the strengths and weaknesses of a particular study design

COURSE MATERIALS

There is one required textbook for this course: **The Art and Science of Social Research by Deborah Carr, Elizabeth Boyle, Benjamin Cornwell, Shelley Correll, Robert Crosnoe, Jeremy Freese, and Mary Waters. SECOND EDITION**

It is fine to use the eBook version of this text. All other course materials will be posted to Canvas.

COURSE POLICIES AND EXPECTATIONS

Academic Misconduct

The University takes academic integrity very seriously. Behaving with integrity is part of our responsibility to our shared learning community. If you're uncertain about if something is academic misconduct, ask me. I am willing to discuss questions you might have.

Acts of academic misconduct may include but are not limited to:

- Cheating (working collaboratively on quizzes/exams and discussion submissions, sharing answers, and previewing quizzes/exams)
- Plagiarism (representing the work of others as your own without giving appropriate credit to the original author(s))
- Unauthorized collaboration (working with each other on assignments)

More information on what constitutes academic misconduct can be found here:

<https://www.washington.edu/cssc/for-students/academic-misconduct/>

In this course, the penalty for the first act of academic dishonesty will be a mandatory meeting with me. The penalty for a second act of academic dishonesty will be an automatic "0" on the assignment and a referral to Community Standards and Student Conduct (CSSC). A third offense will result in automatic failure of the course and another referral to CSSC, which may decide to take further disciplinary action.

Artificial Intelligence Usage

It seems the cat is out of the bag regarding AI use and the classroom. Rather than try to force the cat back into a bag that is no longer big enough to contain it, this course permits some use of AI tools for completing coursework. However, I strongly encourage you to attempt all assignments independently and thoughtfully before reaching for an AI tool. Some amount of struggle is necessary for true learning.

Specifically, students are permitted to use AI-based tools (such as ChatGPT) on some assignments. **The instructions for each assignment will include information about whether and how you may use AI-based tools to complete the assignment. All sources, including AI tools, must be properly cited. Use of AI in ways that are inconsistent with the parameters above will be considered academic misconduct and subject to investigation.**

Please note that AI results can be biased and inaccurate. It is your responsibility to ensure that the information you use from AI is accurate.

Learning how to thoughtfully and strategically use AI-based tools may help you develop your skills, refine your work, and prepare you for your future career. If you have any questions about citation or about what constitutes academic integrity in this course or at the University of Washington, please feel free to contact me to discuss your concerns.

The first penalty for using AI when not permitted or simply copying and pasting outputs from AI tools and presenting them as your own work will be a zero on that assignment. You'll have an opportunity to redo this assignment on your own for full credit. The second penalty is a zero on the assignment and a chance to redo it as your own work for 50%. Third instance is a zero on the assignment with no chance of making it up. If you are concerned about your work being mislabeled as AI produced, I'd encourage you to use tools such as Google Docs that track version history and changes automatically.

Classroom Conduct

A productive intellectual environment requires respectful discussion of ideas and a collaborative approach to learning. There are some basic principles of etiquette to keep in mind in a large classroom with others. A general rule of thumb before doing something you're unsure of is to ask yourself, "If the person beside me was doing XYZ, would it distract me from learning?" If the answer is yes, wait to do it until after class. Some examples of behaviors that you should avoid: showing up to class late, talking while the instructor or another student is speaking to the class, beeps/buzzes/rings from laptops or phones, computer activities that aren't course related (booking travel, online shopping, reading the news, playing video games, etc.), cleaning your dorm or apartment while in class, etc.

ACCOMODATIONS AND RESOURCES

Students with Disabilities

Your experience in this class is important to me. It is the policy and practice of the University of Washington to create inclusive and accessible learning environments consistent with federal and state law. If you have already established accommodations with Disability Resources for Students (DRS), please activate your accommodations via myDRS so we can discuss how they will be implemented in this course.

If you have not yet established services through DRS, but have a temporary health condition or permanent disability that requires accommodations (conditions include but not limited to; mental health, attention-related, learning, vision, hearing, physical or health impacts), contact DRS directly to set up an Access Plan. DRS facilitates the interactive process that establishes reasonable accommodations. Contact DRS at disability.uw.edu.

Counseling Center

The University of Washington Counseling Center offers a variety of options to aid students in dealing with stress, depression, anxiety, adversity, and urgent crises. These options include individual, group, and crisis counseling, as well as workshops and resources designed to enhance student wellness. All Counseling Center services are provided to current UW students free of

charge. In addition, the Counseling Center can connect students with Psychiatric Services if needed. You can schedule and view resources at wellbeing.uw.edu/unit/counseling-center/

Religious Accommodations Policy

Washington state law requires that UW develop a policy for accommodation of student absences or significant hardship due to reasons of faith or conscience, or for organized religious activities. The UW's policy, including more information about how to request an accommodation, is available at <https://registrar.washington.edu/staffandfaculty/religious-accommodations-policy/>. Accommodations must be requested within the first two weeks of this course using the following form <https://registrar.washington.edu/students/religious-accommodations-request/>

COURSE ASSIGNMENTS AND GRADING

In-Class Writings (10%)

Throughout the quarter we will often begin class with a short writing prompt. This can be turned in on Canvas but must be submitted before the end of class. These short writings are designed to get everyone present in the room and thinking about the topic of discussion for the day based on the readings for the week. They are graded credit/no credit based on a good-faith effort of completing the task. You can miss 3 of these with no detriment to your grade.

Weekly Homework (30%)

Each week we will have required readings from our book and from original research articles. I'll post a set of questions related to these readings the Friday before the week we'll read them. Answers to these questions are due Sunday on Canvas. So, you'll have a week + a bit to complete them. You can drop one of these.

Response Memos (30%)

Starting on Week 3, we will have reading memos where you read a brief original research article and identify the following features of the article: 1) research question of interest, 2) the data the author used, 3) the methods used, 4) the main finding, 5) what contribution the author made with this work. The prompts and specific features to identify will vary a bit week to week and you'll receive additional instructions with each assignment, but the core purpose of this task is to get familiar with the reading research articles. You can drop one of these.

Final Exam (30%)

There will be a final exam that will provide an opportunity to demonstrate that you've mastered the core concepts we've covered over the quarter. This will be cumulative (covering material from the full quarter) and will be during our final class meeting.

Syllabus Quiz (2% extra credit)

After the first class, there will be a syllabus quiz that you'll take on Canvas. This assignment is to ensure that you have read the syllabus and understand the course expectations and requirements.

Due Dates

Late work is accepted, however a deduction of 20% is assigned for each 24 hours after an assignment is due. However, I recognize that you all have busy lives and competing priorities with coursework, so with that in mind, you have a total of 5 “flex days” to use as you see fit to extend deadlines over the quarter. You don’t need to tell me that you’re using one of these days. However, you do need to keep track of these days as you use them as I won’t input a final accounting of the late days until I calculate final grades at the end of the quarter. This means that you won’t see a late penalty added to an assignment until later in the quarter if you’ve exceeded the number of allowed flex days. Additionally, if major life events occur with medical or family needs, we can work out a plan for you to complete assignments on an adjusted timeline if needed.

Final Grade Breakdown

All grades will be rounded to the nearest whole number percentage point and assigned letter grades as follows:

A+	96-100%	4.0
A	94-95%	4.0
A-	90-93%	3.7
B+	87-89%	3.4
B	84-86%	3
B-	80-83%	2.7
C+	77-79%	2.4
C	74-76%	2
C-	70-73%	1.7
D+	67-69%	1.4
D	64-66%	1
D-	60-63%	.7
F	<60%	0.0

This syllabus is subject to change at the instructor’s discretion. If I make any changes, I will notify the class via Canvas.

Course Schedule

There are readings listed below each class session. Please complete these readings **BEFORE** coming to class that day so that we can have a productive class session. The content covered in the readings will often be needed to complete in-class exercises and to participate in discussions with your fellow students. Everyone, yourself included, will enjoy the class more if you've done the readings beforehand.

All readings below, unless noted otherwise, are from the textbook. When not from the textbook they will be posted to Canvas under Modules -> Readings.

Week	Date	Day of Week	Topic	Readings	Assignments Due
1	23-Jun-25	Monday	Introduction and Course logistics		
1	24-Jun-25	Tuesday			
1	25-Jun-25	Wednesday	Research Questions and Hypotheses	Chapter 1	
1	26-Jun-25	Thursday			Syllabus quiz
1	27-Jun-25	Friday			
1	28-Jun-25	Saturday			
1	29-Jun-25	Sunday			
2	30-Jun-25	Monday	Measurement, operationalization, defining what we mean	Chapters 2	
2	1-Jul-25	Tuesday			
2	2-Jul-25	Wednesday	Measurement, operationalization + Reading articles	Chapter 4. Ishizuka article	
2	3-Jul-25	Thursday			
2	4-Jul-25	Friday			
2	5-Jul-25	Saturday			
2	6-Jul-25	Sunday			Homework 1 Due

3	7-Jul-25	Monday	Reliability and Validity + Sampling	Chapter 5	
3	8-Jul-25	Tuesday			
3	9-Jul-25	Wednesday	Sampling + Applied Research	Chapter 6, Puget Sound Regional Travel Study (focus on survey methods section)	
3	10-Jul-25	Thursday			
3	11-Jul-25	Friday			
3	12-Jul-25	Saturday			
3	13-Jul-25	Sunday			Homework 2 Due
4	14-Jul-25	Monday	Survey Research	Chapter 7	
4	15-Jul-25	Tuesday			
4	16-Jul-25	Wednesday	Causality, experiments, and quasi-experimental designs	Card, David & Krueger, Alan B. (1994). "Minimum Wages and Employment: A Case Study of the Fast-Food Industry in New Jersey and Pennsylvania."	
4	17-Jul-25	Thursday			Response Memo 1 Due
4	18-Jul-25	Friday			
4	19-Jul-25	Saturday			
4	20-Jul-25	Sunday			Homework 3 Due
5	21-Jul-25	Monday	Controls and confounders	Stack articles	
5	22-Jul-25	Tuesday			
5	23-Jul-25	Wednesday	Ethnographies	Chapter 10; Lareau, Annette. 2002. "Invisible Inequality: Social Class and Childrearing in Black Families and White Families"	
5	24-Jul-25	Thursday			Response Memo 2 Due
5	25-Jul-25	Friday			
5	26-Jul-25	Saturday			

5	27-Jul-25	Sunday			Homework 4 Due
6	28-Jul-25	Monday	Interviews	Chapter 11 Lareau, Annette. 2002. "Invisible Inequality: Social Class and Childrearing in Black Families and White Families"	
6	29-Jul-25	Tuesday			
6	30-Jul-25	Wednesday	Comparative, Historical, and Content Analyses	Chapter 12. Mario Small's chapter on "how many cases do I need"	
6	31-Jul-25	Thursday			Response Memo 3 Due
6	1-Aug-25	Friday			
6	2-Aug-25	Saturday			
6	3-Aug-25	Sunday			Homework 5 Due
7	4-Aug-25	Monday	Univariate and Bivariate relationships + Understanding Regression Tables	Chapter 13	
7	5-Aug-25	Tuesday			
7	6-Aug-25	Wednesday	NO-CLASS	Rosenfeld and Denice 2015. The Power of Transparency: Evidence from a British Workplace Survey	
7	7-Aug-25	Thursday			Response Memo 4 Due
7	8-Aug-25	Friday			
7	9-Aug-25	Saturday			
7	10-Aug-25	Sunday			Homework 6 Due
8	11-Aug-25	Monday	Understanding results from regressions; Human subjects	Chapter 3; Milgram 1963	
8	12-Aug-25	Tuesday			
8	13-Aug-25	Wednesday	Open science, publication bias, and communication to various audiences	Chapter 9 https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/archive/2025/01/business-school-fraud-research/680669/	

8	14-Aug-25	Thursday			Response Memo 5 Due
8	15-Aug-25	Friday			
8	16-Aug-25	Saturday			
8	17-Aug-25	Sunday			Homework 7 Due
9	18-Aug-25	Monday	Reproducible Research and Final exam questions answered	Selections on reproducibility TBA	
9	19-Aug-25	Tuesday			
9	20-Aug-25	Wednesday	Final Exam		